PRODUCT DISCOVERY

Opportunity Exploration

Deciding which problem is worth solving before writing user stories, using the Opportunity Canvas together with stakeholders, customers and developers.

Deciding which problem is worth solving

Between understanding users and writing user stories sits a crucial step that teams often skip: deciding which problem is actually worth solving. The Opportunity Canvas is a lightweight tool for making that decision together with stakeholders, customers and developers, rather than in isolation.

The Opportunity Canvas

The canvas works through five core questions. First, what is the opportunity: what problem are we solving, and how do customers cope with it today. Conversations here tend to drift toward solutions too quickly, so it helps to keep asking why, five times if needed, until the real underlying problem is clear. Second, who are the customer segments that would benefit from solving this problem. Third, what could a possible solution look like, ideally more than one option, starting from the simplest version that could work. Fourth, what are the actual benefits to the customer: how would this help them do something they cannot do today, or do it faster or more easily. Fifth, what does the business need to have in place for the solution to be usable, such as legal, commercial or operational readiness.

Why the conversation matters

The value of the canvas is less about the completed document and more about the conversation it forces. It shifts a team away from opinion-based prioritisation, where the loudest voice or the most senior title wins, toward a shared, evidence-based understanding of what is worth building next. The outcome of this exploration is often expressed as a concrete, near-term objective the team commits to before moving on to the next one, sitting underneath the longer-term product vision.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/product-ownership/opportunity-exploration

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